

Coaching Approach: A Synthesis

Based on analysis of 376 coaching session transcripts across 15+ clients, 20 learning and peer call transcripts, and three prior analytical passes. Client and company names redacted. Analysis period: April 2025 – March 2026.

1. What I Actually Do

The most honest description of my coaching, drawn from nearly 400 transcripts rather than from my own account of it, is this: I hold the tactical problem and the identity question simultaneously and refuse to let sessions become about only one.

When a client arrives navigating a Series C fundraising, a family estrangement, sobriety, and a wedding at the same time, I track all four threads and use each to illuminate the others. When another client receives a progressive neurological diagnosis, I stay in both the medical research and the existential reorientation without ceding ground to either. When a VP of Engineering is managing a difficult CEO relationship, a bipolar condition, a marriage separation, and team performance metrics, I hold all five channels without pretending one is separate from the others.

This dual-track operation — tactics and identity at the same time, without ritual separation — is my core move. I don't slow down to announce "now we're going deeper." I follow the current. The essential assumption is that the person is a coherent system: the business crisis, the family conflict, the health event — these aren't separate compartments to be managed but data about who the person is and what they value.

What makes this mine rather than generic "holistic coaching" is two things. First, the speed and decisiveness with which I move between registers. Second, a strong appetite for naming uncomfortable truths directly. When a client describes his parents' escalating behavior around his engagement, I say "this is emotional abuse." When a leader's 360 feedback reveals chronic over-involvement in operational detail, I surface the specific quote from their CEO that they haven't heard. The naming is fast and precise. It is not gentle. But it is offered as a hypothesis — "does that track?" — not a verdict.

2. Primary Ingredients

Intention-setting as a navigational instrument. Before each session, I write a single sentence capturing what I'm holding for the client — their highest possibility stated in the present tense. These aren't shared as affirmations. They function as my internal compass: a way of holding the developmental direction even when the session covers granular tactics. The intentions shift as the relationship evolves and vary meaningfully by client.

Three forcing questions. I use a consistent set of opening questions across very different client types: *What's the most important decision you haven't yet made? What surprised you about other people recently? What did you experience that you wanted to be different?* These push under the surface narrative to locate what's actually live. They function as a forcing function against agenda-driven drift.

Polarity mapping as a primary framework. I treat apparent value conflicts as complementary tensions requiring navigation rather than resolution. In a co-founder alignment session, this meant structuring an entire mediation around each founder's home pole — one oriented toward innovation and momentum, the other toward openness and conservation — with each owning gift and shadow, naming the other's with respect, then co-designing decisions that serve both. The same lens shows up in individual work: parts of a client that want family connection vs. parts that benefit from separation, building a private practice vs. maintaining institutional dependency.

Assessment and stakeholder interviews as intake. I consistently propose a structured kickoff: personality assessment, observation meetings, 360-style stakeholder interviews, and dashboard review. The stakeholder data often surfaces information the client doesn't have about themselves. I then use this selectively, framing it as pattern rather than report card.

Tactical optimization without apology. I'm genuinely comfortable in the operational layer — restructuring payment systems, co-designing performance management frameworks, building dashboard architectures, drafting internal communications for leadership transitions. I bring domain knowledge about fundraising, org design, and meeting structure into sessions and don't treat this as consulting that dilutes coaching. Clients can bring anything. This creates real breadth of trust, though it also creates a risk I'll name later.

Direct pattern-naming with clinical specificity. I name what I observe with more precision than is comfortable. When a client reads his mother's message about his sister "making the same mistake," I say: "What's the common denominator — mom?" When a leader's team feedback reveals favoritism, I surface it directly. When a CEO is intellectualizing rather than feeling, I name the mechanism. The naming is usually rapid and offered as hypothesis, not pronouncement.

Self-disclosure as professional material. The transcripts show me sharing my partner's company situation in a peer meeting, using my own relationship conflicts as polarity-

mapping material in a group program, and describing my own failure-to-launch narrative and my father's achievement worldview. I use my own life as material. This generates a quality of contact that more professionally guarded coaches cannot replicate — though it means the boundary between personal and professional is thin by design.

3. The Most Meaningful Client Shifts

From intractable co-founder conflict to working framework. Two co-founders arrived describing a values conflict each considered fundamental. Using a structured polarity protocol — each naming their home pole, owning both gift and shadow, naming the other's with respect, translating fears into co-design — the session converted what felt intractable into a shared framework for decision-making. The protocol worked because it refused the binary: it wasn't about choosing one founder's values over the other's, but about designing structures that served both.

Practice-building from inside a conflicted dependency. A coach building her private practice while embedded in an institutional relationship she resented. The work was tactical — network scoring, conference strategy, specific outreach protocols, financial target-setting — combined with the underlying values question: what does a practice look like that doesn't create resentment? She returned from a single business trip with four new prospects, two new clients, and was ending the institutional dependency. The trajectory worked because I didn't try to process the resentment — I helped her build her way out of the conditions creating it.

From performance to sovereignty. One client began the engagement navigating a Series C fundraise alongside a family crisis he'd been managing through substances and appeasement. Over fifteen sessions, the shift was specific and observable: sobriety, clear boundaries, a proposal to his partner, and a principled framework — no coercion, no disrespect, sovereignty, decency — that he applied consistently across months of escalating circumstances while simultaneously closing a major anchor client and advancing the fundraise. The reframe that landed hardest was treating the family re-engagement as a term sheet negotiation: he and his partner as primary stakeholders, the parents as secondary investors with limited leverage and no veto. What enabled this was holding a consistent frame across sessions where the client was clearly oscillating — and refusing to let either the business track or the personal track become the "real" work.

From motorboat urgency to willing presence with illness. A client with a successful investment career and young family received a progressive neurological diagnosis mid-engagement. The early sessions had been about life design — legacy, motivation, what nourishes vs. drains. After the diagnosis, the work shifted but didn't break continuity. I stayed in both registers: treatment research and daily walking protocols alongside the

philosophical reorientation from outcome-focused living to input-focused living. The physical practice was designed as a structural intervention, not a therapy exercise. Poems and a funeral visualization functioned as meaning anchors. The move from “historically outcome-focused — grades, results” to “prioritizing doing my best with inputs, not caring about outcomes” showed up months later as a stable orientation.

4. What's Distinct

I coach toward a specific conception of personhood, not neutrally toward client goals.

The intentions I write — “experiencing the strength to live in full truth,” “experiencing deep peace as he lives aligned with what nourishes him” — reflect a consistent view: the best version of a person is sovereign, purposeful, truthful, and self-referencing rather than other-referenced. Clients who arrive wanting to be better at pleasing their boss, their parents, their board — I consistently introduce friction. I don't just help people get what they want; I interrogate whether they want the right thing.

The integration of psychology and strategy as genuinely inseparable. I don't blend therapeutic and strategic work — I treat them as the same thing. In a single session I'll move from naming a leader's fear of being “the bad guy” to restructuring the executive team to identifying how intellectual honesty has become a defense mechanism. This is possible because I engage with organizational systems — cap tables, M&A sequencing, fundraising mechanics, product-market fit diagnostics — at a level of specificity that gives the inner-world observations credibility.

Cross-domain synthesis as the actual product. I operate across developmental psychology (integral stages, parts work), organizational systems design (stakeholder mapping, dashboard architecture, 360 protocols), a long-standing embodied and ceremonial practice, and an emerging theory of what human intelligence is for in an AI world. I haven't unified these into a coherent external identity — but they are clearly unified internally. They produce a particular presence: someone who can move from “what's alive for you?” to a mood-tracking chart to mythology to feedback on a CEO memo without any of it feeling like a non-sequitur.

Active engagement with the AI question. I've spent the past year developing a genuine intellectual position on how AI changes the practice of coaching and leadership development. The core argument: AI optimized for user satisfaction degrades the conditions for real cognitive development; coaching's irreplaceable role is scaffolding the cognitive complexity that AI cannot hold. I'm building tools (transcription, polarity detection, developmental stage analysis) while simultaneously holding a more alarmed position on AI safety than most of my peers. This is not resolved — but the engagement is serious and ongoing, not performative.

Frameworks deployed by fit, not uniformly. Polarity mapping, sailboat/motorboat leadership, parts work, conscious leadership (above/below the line, drama triangle), structured feedback formats, developmental stage theory — these all appear. But they're selected by fit and often left invisible, delivered as plain-language insight rather than framework application.

5. Honest Limits

The awareness-action gap is my most consistent finding and my most consistent limit.

Clients regularly understand their patterns clearly and continue them anyway. One client's communication style oscillates between approaches across six months of naming it. Another's delegation issues persist through multiple rounds of insight. The transcripts show strong tools for illuminating patterns and fewer tools designed specifically for behavioral pattern interruption — experiments with defined durations, body-based practices that catch the pattern in real-time, accountability structures with visible consequences. Whether this reflects a deliberate philosophy (coaching is about insight, not behavior modification) or a gap worth closing is an open question I'm actively working.

Sessions can drift when there's no external forcing function. Clients who made the most observable progress had significant external pressure — a pending wedding, an M&A process, a financial target. Where external pressure was absent, sessions could become more exploratory and less directional. My coaching amplifies momentum more effectively than it creates it from scratch.

The breadth of the work sometimes crowds out the harder identity confrontation.

When I'm simultaneously a thinking partner on organizational strategy, a personal coach on role identity, an advisor on communication tactics, and a sounding board on energy management — this breadth is valued. But my own private notes sometimes reveal a deeper pattern I've named internally but haven't addressed head-on with the client. The question is whether the tactical value of the work occasionally protects people from the harder conversation.

My preparation can exceed my execution. My session prep notes are often more sophisticated than what the session produces. The gap between plan and execution is real — a detailed co-founder mediation protocol may or may not land with the precision it was designed with. Whether the right intervention is sometimes abandoning the plan rather than landing it is a facilitation craft question I'm still developing.

I am in active development. This past year included leaving a decade-long institutional affiliation, completing a program that meaningfully rebuilt my coaching identity, entering a paid mentorship, growing a solo practice faster than I can manage, and building AI tools for

my own work. My approach is genuinely evolving. Some of what appears as stylistic variability across clients may reflect real uncertainty about what works, not just appropriate adaptation.

6. Where My Thinking Lives

The intellectual territory I'm working in — and the reason I coach the way I do — sits at the intersection of a few commitments that aren't common together:

Human development is real and measurable, but not reducible. I use developmental stage frameworks and believe in the reality of cognitive and emotional development. I also believe the most important parts of that development happen in relational, embodied, often non-rational territory that resists systematization. I hold both of these without resolving them.

AI changes the game for coaching and leadership, and most people in the field aren't reckoning with how. I'm building toward a theory that the human's irreplaceable role in an AI world is scaffolding cognitive complexity — holding the kinds of inquiry that AI optimized for satisfaction cannot support. This has implications for how coaching works, what organizations need from their leaders, and what development means when knowledge is commoditized. I take this seriously as an intellectual project, not just a positioning claim.

The inner life of the practitioner is the instrument. Twenty years of somatic and contemplative practice — including work in indigenous ceremonial traditions — is not peripheral to my coaching capacity. It is likely what accounts for my ability to sit with ambiguity, hold complexity, and work across power dynamics and difference. I don't have a clean professional language for this yet. But it is the ground the work grows from.

Analysis compiled March 2026. All claims sourced from actual transcript content across 396 transcripts spanning April 2025 through March 2026. Client names, company names, and identifying details redacted.